

Houthi escalation risk rises if Saudi offensive targets strongholds

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The Saudi-backed offensive is likely to focus on Houthi-controlled areas near the coast, with strikes on Houthi strongholds to the north likely to bri|||||||||||||

Quick take

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What Happened

Saudi Arabia and forces aligned with Yemen's Riyadh-backed, internationally recognized government launched Operation Dawn of Yemen on 5 October. The first phase aims to retake territory the Houthis captured in recent weeks near the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, although the president of Yemen is vowing to retake the capital Sanaa (see: [Likely Saudi-Houthi escalation raises risk of oil disruptions](#) , 27 September 2026).

Our Take

Riyadh can likely keep escalation contained while its partners recapture recently lost territory. Saudi Arabia has framed its support as a response to recent Houthi attacks on several Saudi cities and to the Yemeni government's stated objective of ultimately ousting the group from Sana'a. But the opening operation is more limited: Yemeni government forces are first working to recover Red Sea coastal territory lost in September. Reportedly supported by 100 Saudi fighter jets, these forces have retaken Dhubab district and the port city of Mokha and are moving north along the coast. The Houthis are likely to resist, but these exposed areas are comparatively vulnerable to Saudi airpower and far from the group's northern strongholds.

However, the calculus will change if they press farther north. The next potential objectives are the strategic Houthi-controlled port of Hodeidah and, eventually, Sana'a. A campaign to take either would move beyond reversing recent Houthi advances and into terrain the group has held for years. Houthi forces would face greater pressure to demonstrate that Saudi Arabia cannot advance without incurring significant costs. The military challenge would also rise: rugged terrain in and around the Houthi heartland would reduce the effectiveness of Saudi airpower and make a ground advance more difficult and prolonged.

In that scenario, the Houthis could expand attacks. Potential targets include Aramco's Jazan refinery, the Yanbu terminal, and the East-West pipeline. Iran and Tehran-backed Iraqi Shia militias would also have stronger incentives to support the Houthis with missile and drone strikes. Potential targets for these groups include the Shaybah oil field, which can produce 1 million barrels a day, as well as the Abqaiq oil processing facility and Ras Tanoura oil terminal in Saudi Arabia's Eastern Province. The resulting risk premium for regional energy exports would rise even if the Houthis do not sustain

successful attacks.

US support will be an important constraint on the campaign's scope and on maritime risks. Riyadh wants Washington to help neutralize Houthi ballistic missiles and launchers, allowing Yemeni forces to retain their momentum while minimizing the risk to Saudi energy. The Trump administration will probably continue providing arms, intelligence, and air-refueling support, but it remains reluctant to enter the conflict directly while it focuses on Iran. Direct US intervention would likely prompt Houthi attacks on US-linked shipping in the Red Sea, which the group currently exempts. The group could also threaten closure of Bab el-Mandeb, although losing further coastal territory would limit its ability to enforce a closure.

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